

Pisoni Fears Curve No Longer; Gets Big Chance With Braves

By Neal Russo

Jim Pisoni, who was headed for the Yankees when a pitch broke his left hand last May, could be opposing the Bombers next October.

"The hand feels fine now, as good as it ever was," said the 28-year-old St. Louisan who was drafted by one pennant winner, the Braves, from the other, the Yankees.

Pisoni, who grew up on The Hill just two blocks from Yogi Berra and Joe Garagiola, has several other incentives for making good in the National League. He was married just two weeks ago to Dorothy Martin, an airline hostess from San Antonio, Tex.; he will have a chance to play again before the home-town folks, including his parents, and he wants to prove to one and all that he has finally conquered the pesky curve ball.

Outlook Rosy.

"I was hitting everything in sight, and they were throwing plenty of curves at me," Pisoni said of his early-season binge in 1958 with Denver in the American Association. It was May and the 5-10 ballhawk with the piercing brown eyes was smashing the ball at a .364 clip with 30 runs batted in and eight home runs—all tops in the league.

Andy Cohen, then manager of Denver, told Jim that he probably would be called up soon by the Yankees. Lee MacPhail, then the Bombers' farm director, visited the Denver club in Minneapolis and hinted strongly that Pisoni would be promoted soon, along with Pitcher Zack Monroe.

Then it happened. "I was looking for a pitch low and outside, but Ron Negray of St. Paul fired it high and tight. I pulled back right away but caught the pitch on my left hand. My index finger was broken, so was the next finger and the one next to that was banged up, too."

It was while the arm was in a cast for seven weeks and Pisoni was sidelined nine weeks that he courted Miss Martin, an attractive brown-eyed brunette flying out of Denver. They met on a blind date.

When Pisoni returned to the lineup, the injured hand and left arm were considerably weaker, he recalled. Jim had to push the ball more instead of taking his customary firm swing, but he finished with a .313 mark with 67 RBIs and 16 homers.

Great News.

"I was at home having dinner when I heard on the radio that

the Braves had drafted me," said the former machinist and burial-vault maker. "Of course I couldn't eat any more, I was so excited and pleased. John Quinn (then the Braves' general manager) called me and told me of the great opportunities in the Milwaukee outfield, with both Bill Bruton and Wes Covington bothered by injuries. I told him I wouldn't give the Braves just 100 per cent effort; instead I promised 200 per cent."

Pisoni, a highly-regarded defensive centerfielder with powerful legs, believes he may platoon in center with lefthanded-hitting Bruton, but he says he's ready to play anywhere in the outfield.

As for his brief period in the Yankees' chain, Pisoni praised the New York organization as being "full of vinegar and fight, like Notre Dame, but they cut my pay when I went to them in the Billy Martin deal for Ryne Duren and a few others, and you know us ball players do have to eat steaks."

Pisoni said he has rejected two contracts sent by the Braves but doesn't expect to have any real difficulty coming to terms.

Pisoni reminisced about his career at the home of his parents, Mr. and Mrs. Ambrose Pisoni, at 1922 Macklind avenue. He recalled switching from softball to baseball at the ripe old age of 17, being turned down at a Yankee try-out as "too small" when he showed up with an uncle's glove, and finally being signed by the Browns for absolutely no bonus and a mere \$150 a month.

After struggling through the minors and suffering a broken ankle in a slide, Jim finally made it to Busch Stadium (then Sportsman's Park) for the last three games of 1953 with the Browns. He had only one hit, but it was a tremendous smash, a home run off the scoreboard with Connie Johnson pitching.

333-Foot Right Field For Coliseum

LOS ANGELES, Jan. 24 (UPI)—The Los Angeles Dodgers today announced that final